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There isn't much Diego Simeone hasn't done at Atletico Madrid but finally, after 15 years, *El Cholo* is a winner at the Nou Camp.

Was it worth the wait? Doubtless Simeone would rather have achieved this first much earlier than his 19th attempt, but the delayed gratification will only add to the buzz of a fabulous victory for Atletico against their all-too-familiar foe in the Champions League quarter-final.

The Rojiblancos did a job on Barca. But don't fall into the trap of assuming it was a backs-to-the-wall triumph of defensive resilience.

That isn't the Atletico way these days. Sure, they were tight, resilient and fought every duel in the manner Simeone himself would. But the Argentinian boss is a changed manager these days and Atletico are a different team to the one we all became used to.

Keegan's Newcastle they are not, but Simeone, presumably against many of his natural instincts, has sacrificed some of the old defensive solidity for attacking fluidity. The best managers evolve, even one seemingly as set in his ways as Simeone, and Atletico are even better value as a result.

We saw Atletico new and old in Barcelona. First, the new-ish.

They took on Barca in consecutive games and went toe-to-toe with Hansi Flick's entertainers. Barca were the victors in Madrid at the weekend, but recognising an insurmountable deficit in La Liga, Simeone rested five key players, all restored for the big one tonight.

The first half hour prompted parallels with last night's entertainment from Spain when Real Madrid and Bayern Munich cared not one jot for control. Two enthralling games featuring four teams, each going for the other's throat. Compared to some of the dross we've become used to in the Premier League, this midweek has been a palate cleanser.

Unsurprisingly given the managers' commitment to attack, both sides created clear openings early on. [Marcus Rashford](#), in from the start after his goal against Atletico on Saturday, was prominent in Barca's best moments but the Manchester United loanee was unable to make the moments matter.

All the signs suggest Barca are keen to keep Rashford, even if we should [prepare for the Catalans to play silly beggars over the fee](#). United must stand firm because £26million is still a steal. If Barca won't pay it, there are plenty who will, even if Rashford would prefer to stay in his 'happy place'.

That being true, the England striker really needed to seize one of his seven chances, the second of which was his clearest.

Rashford is clearly very keen to impress and his appetite must irk United fans who watched him stroll through the final days of his Old Trafford career. But that eagerness appeared to prompt a lack of ruthlessness in his finishing.

When Rashford's fourth attempt failed, the presumption was there would be more given how open the game was. But the game swung shortly after, just before the break, when Giuliano Simeone was

clipped as he burst in behind Pau Cubarsi.

We were as surprised as Simeone when a yellow card was initially issued. DOGSO all day long. And so it was confirmed by VAR.

It was bad enough for Barca before Julian Alvarez curled in a stunning free-kick, prompting memories of Lionel Messi's worldie against Liverpool at the same end in 2019.

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Then it was over to the managers at half-time. Flick made a double change, one of them seeing Robert Lewandowski withdrawn with Rashford's pace deployed through the middle. All the while, Simeone succumbed slightly to his natural instincts.

Rather than seek to capitalise on their spare man in possession, Atletico chose to use their advantage defensively, perhaps expecting the onslaught to come from their wounded hosts.

Simeone recognised there was no need to go chasing the second goal they would regret not scoring. With the attacking quality at his disposal and Barca's tendency to give up opportunities, the chance would come.

His patience paid. And then some. At the end of one of Atletico's rare periods of possession as Barca's intensity waned, Simeone's sub Alexander Sorloth swept home left-back Matteo Ruggeri's fine cross.

The confidence from Barca drained as Atletico's grew. The hosts remained on the front foot but more in hope than belief.

Upon the final whistle, Simeone darted straight up the tunnel. Read into that what you will. Maybe he wanted to savour the moment by himself away from the cameras. Or perhaps it was dash designed to illustrate an understanding that the job remains a long way from finished, despite a once-in-a-generation success for Atletico at the Nou Camp.

If so, it wasn't necessary. Simeone may have evolved but not to the extent that he will allow himself or anyone else to feel too snug with a two-goal advantage.

Because Barca are still in the tie. This was Atletico's first win at the Nou Camp in 20 years but Barca's last victory at the Metropolitano was four days ago. Flick saw enough to believe in Barca, and Simeone will have buzzed off Atletico.

For them and for us, next Tuesday can't come soon enough.

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